

This striking photograph documents a moment of daily life outside a **live poultry market** in New York City, most likely in the **1930s**, capturing a scene that was once common across immigrant neighborhoods in the Lower East Side and East Village.

What's Happening in the Image?

At the center of the frame is a stack of **wooden poultry crates**, filled with live **chickens**, with their heads and feathers visible through the slats. Customers stand to the right, while a woman near the doorway is shown **handling a freshly slaughtered chicken**, likely just prepared on site. This kind of direct-to-consumer, small-scale poultry sale was typical before refrigeration and supermarkets.

To the left, a **crate labeled "GROUMET"** is filled with hay or straw—perhaps used for packaging or cushioning. Behind it hangs a **handwritten sign reading "EGGS 15¢"**, suggesting that the shop also sold **fresh eggs**, likely from the very hens stacked nearby.

People in the Scene

Several figures, mostly **women dressed in coats and hats**, wait patiently to make their purchases. One man in a **fedora and suit** stands near the front of the frame holding a shopping bag or briefcase. The woman in the center—perhaps the butcher or assistant—is shown either handing over or wrapping up a pair of **plucked, head-on chickens**.

To the far left, partially obscured, is a **young child**, possibly accompanying a parent, which adds a personal, humanizing touch to the scene. The photo reflects the **intimate, community-based commerce** of the era, where shopping was hands-on and deeply embedded in daily ritual.

Setting and Cultural Context

The photograph was likely taken in front of **C. Guerrieri's poultry shop** at **325 First Avenue**, a business shown in another related image. This block, in Manhattan's East Village, was known in the 1920s–40s for its **Italian-American and Eastern European Jewish population**, many of whom kept to food traditions that included selecting **live poultry for kosher or fresh preparation**.

Shops like this would have lined First Avenue and nearby side streets, serving neighbors with **live chickens, fresh eggs, and seasonal fare**, often with signs in multiple languages.

Estimated Date: 1932–1936

Several clues point to the early-to-mid 1930s:

- **Clothing:** The coats, hats, and shoes reflect fashion typical of the Depression era.
 - **Price signage:** "Eggs 15¢" is consistent with Depression-era pricing.
 - **Street-level retail setup:** Crates and live poultry visible to the street were phased out or restricted later due to health codes.
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Cultural Insight

This image powerfully evokes a time when **food buying was personal, direct, and physical**. Customers chose their poultry by eye, often knowing the butcher by name. It also illustrates the **resilience and adaptability** of immigrant communities during the Depression, maintaining food traditions even in crowded, urban environments.